

Suddenly I started becoming aware of my parents' spending, and like a rookie financial detective, tried to piece together how we were affording our new lives. Where had the money for my—and now my sister's—uniforms, books, and tuition been coming from? Where was the money for my upcoming bat mitzvah coming from? If we didn't have enough money, how had we been paying for everything before? Turns out we weren't. A lot of the money came from loans or credit cards, much of which my parents still won't reveal to me. The rest of our life was often bankrolled by my mother's bartering. Instead of taking money from clients who a lot of the time couldn't afford to pay her for her legal services, I found out my mom was rendering them for trades.

Some things we got for “free” were:

Haircuts

Nail salon visits

Flowers

Bedroom furniture

Jewelry

Party planning for my bat mitzvah

Tailors

And who knows what else? If a crate of salad dressing showed up at the house, it was probably because my mom had handled the divorce of the HR department head for Kraft. When I confronted her in fall 2016 about not really ever making the money back on the work she'd done, she replied simply, “There were children who needed my help.” But she didn't have an answer when I pointed out that she too had her own children, who could have benefited from her getting paid properly.

What came next is probably familiar to any Jewish child out there: guilt. She immediately started in with: “So I guess you're saying you had a terrible childhood?” No! The opposite.

My parents overspent because they wanted to give us “life experiences.” The huge financial consequences of a family vacation or party, in their minds, were worth the smiles on our faces and the full photo albums. Would I trade in the